were cast, poems and odes composed, prisoners released, and alms distributed. The drummers began a clangorous music as dancers swayed and twirled in front of the Padshah. Scented water was poured on the heads of courtiers as blessing and royal banquets were arranged for seven days of celebrations. At Sikri, meanwhile, the baby Salim was much admired by adoring ladies. The birth chamber was a place of subdued joy, as the new mother was gently tended to by an older woman in Timurid dress. The women surrounding the mother and infant would have heard music spilling out from the courtyard, where drummers played large naqqara drums, while behind them men blew into trumpets, and enthusiastically smashed cymbals together.

In January 1570, Akbar set off on foot from Agra to fulfil a vow he had made to walk to the Ajmer shrine if ever he were granted a son. Members of his harem, including Harkha Bai, and the infant Salim also travelled to Ajmer. When Akbar arrived at Ajmer, he gave such a huge donation in gold and money to the shrine that it resulted in charges of misappropriation and embezzlement and a general outcry among the attendants of the dargah. A dispute arose over the question of who among the shrine's several attendants was most deserving of the huge donation. Hearing of this unseemly behaviour, Akbar dismissed all the attendants and appointed his own officer, Shaikh Muhammad Bukhari, 'a wise and respectable saint', and a nobleman of the court, as keeper of the dargah. Mosques and a khanqah were built at the dargah and, in the course of the year, Akbar would begin work on a fortress and palace at Ajmer. He would also gift kettledrums to the dargah and would initiate customs at the shrine that mimicked those of the Mughal court. In these many ways Akbar cleaved to his own persona, and bequeathed to his son the lustrous legacy of the Sufi saints. What was remarkable was that Akbar had emphatically turned away from the Naqshbandi Sufis, traditional partners of Central Asian rulers, and had chosen the Chishtiya Sufis of Hindustan.

Beginning in the Mawarannahr* region that the Timurids came from, the Naqshbandi khwajas believed they had a clear duty to protect all Muslim subjects from oppression even if that meant 'trafficking with Kings and conquering their souls'. Babur himself wrote of dreams in which he saw the powerful Naqshbandi Sufi Khwaja Ahrar in dreams. But by the time Akbar was strengthening his empire in the 1570s, the milieu had become decidedly uncongenial for the Naqshbandis, who not only advocated the